Name: **Roll No:** **Batch:**

Pre-reading Activity:

1. What comes to your mind when you hear the term "AI education"?
2. AI is increasingly being introduced into education. What benefits and challenges do you think it might create for students from different social and economic backgrounds?
3. Do you think access to technology leads to equal educational opportunities? Why or why not?

Active Reading - As you read the article, focus on how each paragraph develops its main idea.

- Identify the topic sentence: Underline the sentence that expresses the main idea of each paragraph. If the topic sentence is not stated directly, write the main idea in the margin.
- Identify supporting details and their types in each paragraph
- Evaluate paragraph unity: After reading each paragraph, ask: Does every supporting detail relate directly to the topic sentence? Mark any sentence that seems unrelated or only loosely connected to the paragraph's main idea.

Equity, access must be part of AI education

Across India's vast and diverse educational landscape, a silent shift is underway, but not one of replacement or disruption alone.

With over 250 million students in schools and many more in higher education, the narrative that Artificial Intelligence (AI) will simply enter and transform Indian education is not just simplistic; it's grossly misleading. It belies a complex reality - as AI enters the ecosystem, India's many education systems will also shape it in return. This is not a story of technology replacing tradition.

It is one of mutual engagement that is fluid, contextual, and necessarily adaptive. Unlike in many countries, India does not have one singular education system. Our learning spaces range from expensive private schools in metropolitans to government-run village classrooms, from digital-first urban universities to informal local knowledge hubs. Each of these responds differently to change, and AI will be no exception. Consequently, AI will not deliver a uniform impact and must be designed to respond to India's plural realities. Just as our classrooms are diverse, so too will be

the ways AI is adopted and adapted. Globally, AI is being rapidly integrated into education systems to prepare students for an uncertain future.

According to the World Economic Forum, nearly 40 per cent of core job skills are expected to change in the next five years. Consequently, AI literacy is becoming as important of a building block as reading or arithmetic. It is not only about using technology but also about thriving in a world intensively shaped by it. In this context, India cannot afford to lag. However, our response must be rooted in the understanding that any AI-for-education strategy must mirror the diversity, decentralization, and dynamism of Indian education itself. India already has the beginnings of a supportive policy environment in the shape of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. However, to truly succeed, these efforts need to fit different local contexts rather than be copied the same way everywhere. The real test is not whether AI can support education.

It is about how AI will be experienced across India's many learning environments. To understand its true impact, we need to look beyond technical potential and focus on how students, teachers, and communities actually use it in everyday settings. Some possibilities like personalized learning and teacher support are already showing promise. These, too, need to be shaped by the diverse realities of Indian education. One of the most promising areas is personalized learning. In theory, AI can tailor lessons to each student's pace, strengths, and learning gaps.

In practice, this can look very different dep ending on the environment. In a pilot by NITI Aayog, AI-powered tutoring led to a 40 per cent improvement in learning outcomes by identifying and addressing individual needs. Yet, the impact of such tools in a rural school with limited connectivity versus an urban private institution with tech-savvy staff will vary. A personalized algorithm must also be context-aware. Equally important is how AI is reshaping the role of teachers. Across contexts, educators are moving beyond being content-deliverers to becoming mentors, facilitators, and co-learners. AI can take over administrative tasks like grading or attendance, freeing up teachers to focus on student engagement, critical thinking, and emotional support.

But this transformation cannot be top-down. Teachers must have the agency to shape how they use these tools in their unique contexts. In a multilingual classroom, for example, teachers may rely on AI-powered translation or speech tools to support their teaching. Outside schools, higher education and lifelong learning are also being reimagined. AI is making continuous learning more

accessible, especially through self-paced modules in regional languages. Government initiatives like “AI for All” are already expanding digital literacy to broader audiences. Nonetheless, it is useful to recall that the reception and effectiveness of such programs depend on infrastructure, cultural attitudes, and existing pedagogical traditions in different communities.

This brings us to the most critical concern: equity and access. Technology does not enter a neutral field. Its impact is shaped by, and can reinforce, existing inequalities. Students without reliable internet or devices may be left out, deepening the digital divide. AI tools trained on biased or limited data sets may disadvantage certain linguistic, social, or regional groups. We are already seeing AI being used to translate complex engineering content into Indian languages, but we must go further. Inclusion must be built into the foundation, not added as an afterthought.

To mitigate these risks, ethical oversight and local governance are vital. AI in education must be accountable, and its design and deployment must be transparent and inclusive. Educators, developers, policymakers, and even students must be part of shaping how these tools evolve. India’s education transformation will not come from importing readymade solutions. It will require co-creating systems that recognize the diversity of learners and empower teachers to adapt tools meaningfully.

Ultimately, AI in Indian education must be a story of interaction over replacement. Our systems will shape AI just as AI will shape them. This dynamic exchange, rooted in India’s diversity, is an important strength. If we combine innovation with local insight, India’s classrooms can become models of adaptive, inclusive, and future-ready learning. AI will not transform education for us; we will shape that transformation together, with care and context.

(By Ramanand - The writer is Director, Center of Policy Research and Governance.)

Source: Originally published in *The Statesman*, 20 September 2025. Reproduced for educational purposes. [https://www.thestatesman.com/opinion/equity-access-must-be-part-of-ai-education-1503488916.html]

Part I: Discuss the following questions and write down the answers briefly in one or two sentences:

1. Why does the writer believe that AI tools should be adapted to local contexts?

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2. What does the writer suggest India should do instead of importing ready-made AI solutions?

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3. Do you think teachers should take new roles with the support of AI? Why?

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Part II: Thinking Critically

1. The article presents personalized learning as one of AI's major benefits. Do you think personalized learning through AI can replace the human understanding and emotional support provided by teachers? Why or why not?

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2. Do you think providing the same AI tool to students in different social and economic contexts is enough to ensure fairness? Why or why not?

3. The writer concludes that “we will shape that transformation together.” Who should have the greatest responsibility for ensuring that AI benefits all learners - governments, technology companies, teachers, or educational institutions? Justify your choice.

4. If you were responsible for introducing AI into a rural school, what three steps would you take to ensure that students benefit from the technology?

Part III: Paragraph Writing Task

Write a well-developed paragraph of 150–200 words reflecting on an idea from the readings that made you rethink the process of learning. Your paragraph should include:

- a clear topic sentence stating your main idea
- relevant supporting details, such as examples, reasons, explanations, facts, or analysis
- logical connections between your ideas and
- a concluding sentence that reinforces your main idea.